

they wanted to make every scene in the game striking enough that it'd be something you print out and hang on your wall. Monument Valley may be a deceptively simple isometric puzzler, but it asks important questions about videogames as art. Arthouse indie titles like Dear Esther and The Witness approach this question from more oblique angles, but Monument Valley tackles it head-on, with absolutely stunning art design.



The broad strokes of primary colour and the flat shading make it an exceptional standout on high resolution displays—it really does feel like something you could print out and stick on your wall, level after level.

INFINITY BLADE

Straight-up ports of older-generation titles do work, but come with all the limitations of cramming a 10-15 year-old big-screen experience onto your phone — virtual controls end up covering half the screen and you'll probably run out of battery before hitting the first save point. That being said, what about "console quality" games built from the ground up for mobile? Epic turned a lot of heads when it brought the Unreal 3 engine over to iOS back in 2010. Epic Citadel was a remarkable showcase of what your iPhone 3GS was capable of. Then Chair went ahead and created Infinity Blade, an actual mobile title running on Unreal 3.

In terms of visuals, Infinity Blade does live up to the "console quality" promise, though the lack of free move-



ment and limited camera angles does lessen the wow-factor somewhat. But more than just being a looker, Infinity Blade delivered an experience that was tailored specifically towards a mobile audience. The swipe-based combat system, taking a cue from Fruit Ninja, is intuitive yet hard to master. The one-on-one fights have an epic setpiece grandeur, but don't last more than a few minutes, breaking play into bite-sized chunks. Infinity Blade is a remarkable example of a mobile title pushing the boundaries in terms of visuals, while still having an appreciation for the platform it's played on.

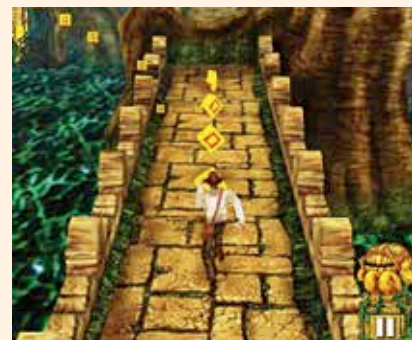
CANABALT

Before Temple Run, there was Canabalt. The endless runner is a genre that could only have done well on mobile. Simple mechanics, one-touch controls, and (endless) replayability make endless runners the go-to when you need to kill time. Canabalt's minimalist aesthetic and black and white presentation exude a sense of mystery. Who is that guy? Why does he jump out a window and run over rooftops? Canabalt may not enjoy the popularity it deserves, but it introduced the world to the endless runner genre. And with an HD remaster out, it's definitely worth checking out.

TEMPLE RUN

Canabalt is like the hipster of endless runners: It was an endless runner before endlessly running became mainstream. Temple Run, on the other hand, is about as mainstream as it gets. It's also a fantastic example of free-to-play done right. F2P titles are maligned all too often for being shameless cashgrabs, and unfortunately, that is the case most of the time. Free-to-play wouldn't be a thing unless publishers made money off it, but there's still something about paying for game-breaking items, or even to refill the "energy meter" that leaves a bad taste in the mouth.

Temple Run is meant to be enjoyed over short intervals. It's easy to pick up but relatively difficult to master, and while there are clear progression paths, it doesn't lock any of the fun



parts out behind a payment or experience wall. The running, and sliding, and getting skewered are all there for free, though you could buy some extra goodies, if you wanted. And that attitude — provide people with a game-play experience they'll enjoy and give them the option to pay if they want to — is likely what drove Temple Run's phenomenal success.

CARDBOARD VR GAMES

VR's all set to be an actual thing this year. The Oculus Rift and HTC Vive have finally started shipping. Over here in India, Absentia's Tesseract HMD is set to make waves as a more affordable alternative that'll run all your PC games right out of the box. But looking at the sales figures, high-end, "dedicated" VR systems make up but a small fraction — less than 15 percent — of VR hardware sold over the past year. Smartphone VR is where the money's at. There are already a plethora of games and VR experiences up on the Play Store, designed for Google Cardboard. We recently tried Zombi-estan VR and it was every bit as rubbish as the name suggests — a handful of maps, each about the size of a dorm room, with randomly spawning zombies. But it, and many other Cardboard VR titles are suggestive of better things to come. The developers of Alien Apartment VR make it clear that the demo is a proof-of-concept and that a full-fledged Cardboard VR game is on its way. We're still a ways off from experience real quality content in the Google Cardboard ecosystem, but the growing number of Cardboard VR apps strongly suggests that good things are to come. *